

A LITANY OF LAMENT

Disillusioned with contemporary India, the author parades his peeves for bleeding-heart applause



**THE SECOND PARTITION: FAULT-LINES
IN INDIA'S DEMOCRACY**

by PATWANT SINGH

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■ By Chandan Mitra

There are two types of people that run India down with breathless desperation. The first comprises NRIs who migrated because of indigent circumstances at home and now rant viciously against everything Indian, as a defence mechanism against the second-class treatment they receive in their domicile. And the second category consists of people like Patwant Singh. Arguably, he is no second-class citizen. According to the eulogy published on the backcover, a Western author says Singh "returns to the fray with a sharp and unforgiving view of the country he loves". If India has lovers like him, I shudder to think what haters would be like.

Patwant Singh's unrequited love for contemporary India is transparent from chapter headings such as: "Oppressing Women and Neglecting the Sick", "Go Thirsty and Be Damned", "Who Cares About the Unemployed?", "Rules, Rituals, Rigmarole", and so on. The author argues his case with a sledgehammer where a scalpel might have sufficed. Whatever he writes has been said before, but for those NGOs still on the lookout for suitable financiers, this book will come in handy to bolster their claim to wads of greenbacks. *The Second Partition* could well become a substitute for a begging bowl.

The author gets a brain-wave about the reason for failing to feed hungry mouths: "From 1999 to 2004, under the BJP-led coalition government, India's growth rate of food-grain output was lower than

the growth rate of its population, for the simple reason that population control was not a priority." If India's population has more than trebled since 1947, surely the Congress also had something to do with it? And if India's agricultural growth rate is at its lowest under Manmohan Singh's tutelage, population growth cannot be the only reason. But BJP-bashing sells; India-baiting has sex appeal in the West.

Patwant Singh compares malnutrition figures in Bihar and Madhya Pradesh unfavourably with sub-Saharan Africa. In his view, India's other half is in the league of Puerto Rico, Chad, Burkina Faso and such bywords for underdevelopment. Showcasing India's poverty, mal-administration, mis-governance, political sleaze, insensitivity and all things negative, Singh relentlessly badgers his point home. He thunders against the Bombay Municipal Corporation

INDIA-BASHING: The author argues his case with a sledgehammer

and demands pavement dwellers be provided "decent housing", not merely the right to squat on pavements. He rails against the displacement of "tribals" by the Sardar Sarovar Project, conveniently overlooking the Supreme Court's recent verdicts on the issue. No wonder his footnotes bristle with references to Amartya Sen, Medha Patkar and Left-wing commentators.

While one can largely ignore the author's pet peeves as an unsophisticated attempt to garner bleeding-heart applause, his grossly misleading chapter on Hinduism versus the Rest is offensive for its ignorance. Not only does he translate *varna* as caste when caste means *jati*, and calls Adi Sankara Adi Shankaracharya, he glosses over caste divisions in other religions practised in India. He does not mention that the Shiromani Gurdwara Prabandhak Committee reserves 25 per cent of its elective posts for Mazhabis, or Scheduled Caste converts to Sikhism. Naturally, he does not refer to OBC quotas being availed by "backward" Muslims under the Mandal Commission's recommendations, or to the extension of the SC quota to neo-Buddhists. Playing to his targeted constituency, the author throbs with anger at the alleged persecution of Christians in India. In comparison, the Babri Masjid's demolition is dealt with in less than a paragraph.

The author has a serious problem with India's alleged militarisation, but not a word is said about Pakistan, China, Tibet, the Taliban, or even global terrorism. These, clearly, are inconvenient minutiae that interrupt the flow of his agenda. Mahatma Gandhi, whom Singh frequently invokes to lament India's decline and fall, had described Katherine Mayo's *Mother India* as a "drain inspector's report". I rest my case.



SHAILESH RAVAL